Narendra Modi is never one to rest on his laurels. On December 5, the final day of the voting, when it was evident that the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) was heading for a historic win in the assembly election in his home state, the prime minister was already thinking ahead. He has set his eyes on the bigger prize—the 2024 General Election—which he wants to win for the BJP for a third consecutive term. Soon after he made a public show of casting his vote in Ahmedabad's Nishant High School—which had the Opposition crying foul, claiming that it violated the election code of conduct—Modi took a flight back to the national capital. From the airport, he drove straight to the BJP's headquarters at Deendayal Upadhyay Marg to conduct a two-day review meeting with national office-bearers, the state *prabharis* and the state unit chiefs of preparations for nine states that will go to the polls in 2023 and to chalk out the roadmap to ensure his party's victory in 2024.

The blockbuster win in Gujarat has convincingly established that the Modi magic endures. Despite the massive anti-incumbency accruing from 27 years in power, the BJP won 156 of the total 182 seats, surpassing the highest ever mandate of 149 seats that the Congress won in 1985. There was little doubt that like the party's campaign in Gujarat, the BJP's victory too was largely won in the name of Modi. Decisiveness being a key Modi trait, the prime minister did not shy from sacking the chief minister Vijay Rupani and his entire cabinet when internal polls last year indicated that the BJP was headed for defeat. In Rupani's place was propped up the relatively unknown Bhupendra Patel, a first-time MLA and former Ahmedabad municipal councillor, and a whole set of new faces. For the election itself, the BJP dropped many heavyweights to give a third of the seats to first-timers.

Modi was also not willing to leave anything to chance. The prime minister unleashed a relentless campaign in the state, addressing over 30 rallies, capped with magnificent road shows in Surat and Ahmedabad. He appealed to Gujarati *asmita* (sense of pride), asking the electorate to strengthen his hands to serve them better both at the Centre and in the state. He also cleverly coined the slogan 'I have made this Gujarat' to remind people that they had a personal stake in electing him. His blitzkrieg subsumed intra-party rebellion, factionalism and anti-incumbency that had earlier threatened the BJP in its bastion. As Sambit Patra, the national spokesperson of the BJP, colourfully put it, "PM stands for not just prime minister but '*pasina*' (sweat) and '*mehnat*' (toil), which Modiji demonstrated right through, setting an example for much younger leaders in terms of stamina and effort apart from charisma."

WHILE GUJARAT WAS CAUSE FOR CELEBRATION, THE DEFEATS IN HIMACHAL AND DELHI ARE SOBERING REMINDERS FOR THE BJP TO NURTURE STRONGER STATE LEADERS

But if the massive win in Gujarat cemented Modi's stature as the BJP's trump card, the defeat in Himachal Pradesh has come as a sobering reminder of the need to have strong state leaders to buck anti-incumbency trends. That was also brought home by the results of the Delhi municipal elections, in which though the BJP did better than expected, its 15-year reign was brought to an end by the Aam Aadmi Party, which emerged as the winner for the first time. Results in the bypolls across the country were a mixed bag for the BJP, but it does need to take heed of the Opposition's good show in some states. Dimple Yadav winning the family bastion of Mainpuri was only to be expected; Samajwadi Party ally Rashtriya Lok Dal won the Khatauli assembly seat. The BJP, though, did manage to wrest Azam Khan stronghold, Rampur. In Rajasthan, the Congress won the Sadarshahar assembly seat, in a validation of the party's continuing hold on the Ashok Gehlot-ruled state. None of the upcoming assembly elections or even the 2024 Lok Sabha election will be the cakewalk that Gujarat has proved to be for the BJP and its talismanic leader.